MODULE 4

Module 4: Color & Bleaching

6 techniques · 18 video lessons



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> *Color work is where a barber's craft meets chemistry. Done well, it adds contrast, texture and confidence to a haircut. Done carelessly, it can cause burns, allergic reactions and damaged hair. This module teaches the **concepts and workflow** behind men's color and bleaching so you understand what is happening at every step.*

The golden rule: the manufacturer's instructions win

Every color, lightener, developer and toner is formulated differently. Mixing ratios, processing times and strand-test guidance are printed on the product or on the manufacturer's data sheet, and they change between products and even between batches. This course deliberately gives **no brand-specific proportions**. Always follow the instructions that come with the exact product in your hand, and never combine products that were not designed to be used together.

> **Non-negotiable safety habits**
>
> Perform a patch test at least 48 hours before every chemical service. Wear gloves, work in a well-ventilated room, protect the client's skin and eyes, and never mix unknown products. If a client has had a reaction before, or the skin is broken, irritated or sunburned, do not proceed.

What you will learn

1. Hair color basics: levels, undertones and how to read a starting point.
2. Permanent pigmentation for men: covering grays and deepening natural color.
3. Platinum bleach: lifting dark hair safely and keeping it healthy.
4. Aligned highlights: placing lighter pieces that follow the haircut.
5. Toning: neutralizing unwanted warmth after lifting.
6. Safety, patch tests and aftercare: the protocol behind every service.

The consultation comes first

Before you open a single bottle, ask about the client's color history, medications, scalp conditions, previous reactions and the result they actually want. Many men underestimate how much work platinum requires from dark brown or black hair, and some cannot reach their goal in one visit without compromising hair integrity. Honest expectations protect both of you.

Know your limits

Some situations belong with an experienced professional colorist: heavy previous bleaching, box-dyed hair of unknown history, chemically relaxed or straightened hair, severe scalp irritation, and any request that would need several lightening sessions. Referring a client onward is a sign of professionalism, not weakness.

Licensing reminder

In many places, performing chemical services on clients requires a barber or cosmetology license. Check your local licensing requirements before offering color professionally. The certificate of completion in this course is not a license.

About the video lessons

This module lists 18 curated public video lessons from experienced barbers, linked from their original channels. They belong to their creators and links can change over time. Every technique also has complete written steps, so you can follow it without the videos.

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1. Hair color basics (levels and undertones)

> *Read a client's natural level and undertone so you can predict how any color or lightener will behave.*

Estimated practice time: 45-60 minutes

Tools you need

- Level chart or swatch ring
- Wide-tooth comb
- Natural daylight or daylight-balanced lamp
- Notebook or client record card
- Gloves

Step by step

1. Work in neutral lighting. Warm bulbs hide or exaggerate undertones, so use daylight or a daylight-balanced lamp whenever possible.
2. Learn the level scale: hair is rated from very dark (level 1, black) to very light (level 10, lightest blonde). Most men's natural hair sits between levels 2 and 6.

3. Part the hair at the crown and compare a clean, dry section to your swatch ring. Hold the swatch against the hair, not against the scalp or skin.
4. Identify the underlying pigment. Dark hair lifts through red, then orange, then yellow, then pale yellow. Whatever warm tone shows at the stage you stop is the undertone you will see.
5. Check for gray or white hair. Estimate the percentage and note where it is concentrated (temples, sideburns, beard line) because those areas often process differently.
6. Look for previous color. Compare roots to lengths, ask what was used and when, and check for banding or dull, flat tones that signal old dye.
7. Assess condition: dry, porous or brittle hair absorbs color faster and unevenly, while resistant hair may need longer processing within the manufacturer's limits.
8. Record the starting level, undertone, gray percentage and condition on the client card, and compare it to the target level so you know how many levels of change are really involved.
9. Decide whether the goal is realistic in one session. If the gap is large, explain a staged plan or refer to a professional colorist.

Common mistakes

- Judging level under warm salon lighting.
- Comparing the swatch to the scalp instead of the hair strand.
- Ignoring previous color and treating the hair as virgin.
- Promising a result without noting the underlying undertone.
- Skipping the client record, then forgetting what was done.

Practice drill

Collect five hair swatches or mannequin sections of different levels. Without looking at the labels, assign a level and a dominant undertone to each, then check your answers. Repeat until you are right on at least four of five.

> **Safety note**
> Do not make color decisions on irritated, broken or sunburned skin, and never skip the consultation questions about allergies and previous reactions.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
The Level System & Underlying Pigment | Color Theory for hairstylists Part 1 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SH8Tgp_hoOw	Lorena Paints	Level system and underlying pigment explained for hairstylists
Chapter 1: Professional Hair Color Levels Explained https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=54fVeezGwVM	Zotos Professional	Professional color levels explained from the start

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Hair Color Theory Explained | Level 1–10 Underlying Pigment & Neutralization | Hairstylist #shorts https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kPccYco6nHw	Hairstylist Fahim	Levels 1-10, underlying pigment and neutralizing unwanted tones

2. Permanent pigmentation (permanent color) for men

> *Apply permanent color to cover grays or deepen natural color, following the manufacturer's instructions exactly.*

Estimated practice time: 60-90 minutes

Tools you need

- Permanent color and matching developer from the same system
- Non-metallic bowl and tint brush
- Gloves
- Barrier cream and cape
- Sectioning clips
- Timer
- Shampoo and cool water access
- Strand-test cards

Step by step

1. Read the manufacturer's instructions for the exact product before you open anything. Note mixing guidance, application method and maximum processing time.
2. Confirm that a patch test was done at least 48 hours earlier with no reaction. If not, stop and reschedule.
3. Put on gloves, cape the client and apply barrier cream around the hairline, ears and neck to prevent skin staining.
4. Do a strand test on a hidden section if you are unsure of the result, and let it develop for the time stated by the manufacturer.
5. Prepare the mixture in a non-metallic bowl exactly as the instructions direct. Never guess ratios and never mix products from different systems.
6. Section the hair and apply to the areas needing coverage first, usually the grays at the temples and crown, working with thin, controlled brush lines.
7. Apply to the remaining hair, keeping the product off the skin. Wipe stray color from the skin immediately with a damp cloth.
8. Start your timer when application is complete. Check progress visually at the recommended interval without exceeding the maximum time on the label.

9. Rinse thoroughly with lukewarm water until it runs clear, then shampoo with a gentle, color-safe product and condition.
10. Dry, check evenness in daylight, and record the product, timing and result on the client card.

Common mistakes

- Skipping the patch test or strand test.
- Mixing products from different systems or improvising ratios.
- Letting color sit past the manufacturer's maximum time.
- Applying color to the skin without barrier cream.
- Rinsing with water that is too hot, which irritates the scalp.

Practice drill

Practice sectioning and brush control with plain water on a mannequin head until you can cleanly cover only the target areas. Then do a real color application on a mannequin using the exact instructions of one product.

> **Safety note**
> Gloves and ventilation at all times. Keep color away from eyes. If the client reports burning, itching or swelling, rinse immediately and stop the service. Refer severe reactions to medical care.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Dye Hair at Home | Easy Men's coloring Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bgjyz0lQkX0	BOB THE BARBER	Step-by-step permanent hair color application on a male client
Hair Colour Transformation | Men Hair Dye | Fast Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6Lo-Y3921E8	BOB THE BARBER	Fast barber workflow for coloring men's hair
BIGEN HAIR DYE TUTORIAL | BY WILL PEREZ https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3l-DGzky508	Will Perez	Applying permanent dye with a barber's practical tips

3. Platinum bleach

> *Understand and carry out a careful lightening service, and know when a goal needs a professional colorist or several sessions.*

Estimated practice time: 2-3 hours

Tools you need

- Lightener and compatible developer chosen per manufacturer
- Non-metallic bowl and brush

- Gloves and apron
- Barrier cream
- Foils or clips
- Timer
- Strand-test supplies
- Bond-care or conditioning treatment recommended by the manufacturer

Step by step

1. Consult first. Check starting level, previous color, hair condition and scalp health. Explain that platinum from dark hair can take multiple sessions.
2. Complete a patch test at least 48 hours before service and a strand test on a hidden section to see how the hair responds.
3. Do not lighten hair that is damaged, previously bleached with unknown history, chemically relaxed or when the scalp is irritated. Refer to a professional colorist instead.
4. Ventilate the room, put on gloves and protect the skin and eyes. Apply barrier cream around the hairline.
5. Mix the lightener and developer strictly according to the manufacturer's instructions. Never substitute or add other products.
6. Apply to the hair starting where processing is slowest, usually away from the scalp, and leave the roots for later because body heat speeds lifting there.
7. Add product to the roots with thin, careful lines, keeping a small gap from the scalp if the instructions advise it.
8. Monitor visually and by strand checks. Remove product when the desired lift is reached or the maximum time is hit, whichever comes first.
9. Rinse with lukewarm water, shampoo gently and apply the conditioning treatment recommended by the manufacturer.
10. Assess the result in daylight. If the hair is still too warm, plan toning (technique 5) rather than leaving the lightener on longer.

Common mistakes

- Leaving lightener on past the maximum time to reach a goal.
- Starting at the roots where heat accelerates processing.
- Bleaching damaged or unknown-history hair.
- Mixing bleach with random additives.
- Forgetting to explain the maintenance and conditioning that platinum needs.

Practice drill

Practice on a bleach-safe mannequin or test swatches, working strictly to the instructions of one lightener. Record the time and level reached at each check so you learn how the hair responds.

> **Safety note**
>
> Lightener can burn skin and damage hair. Never leave a client unattended, never exceed the label's maximum time, and rinse at once if there is burning or discomfort. Seek medical help for chemical burns.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Platinum blonde hair for men - how to bleach men's hair - Silver Fox hair https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rqpCZRV2NyI	Slikhaar TV - Mens hair	Bleaching men's hair to platinum and silver, step by step
How To Dye Your Hair Platinum Blonde - Mens Hair Tutorial 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bNz7DXcUaKQ	Jake Daniels	Lifting to platinum blonde with a men's hair tutorial
DIY Platinum Blonde for Men | Dark Hair to Blonde https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=E_dM4CRje1U	Prince (Like the Artist)	Dark hair to platinum blonde: lifting process and expectations

4. Aligned highlights

> *Place lighter pieces that follow the haircut's shape, such as a faded top or textured crop.*

Estimated practice time: 90-120 minutes

Tools you need

- Lightener and developer per manufacturer
- Foils or highlight cap with hook
- Tint brush
- Tail comb
- Sectioning clips
- Gloves and cape
- Timer

Step by step

1. Finish the haircut first, or leave the length slightly long if the cut will be refined afterward, so the highlights land in the correct place.
2. Decide where the lightest pieces should sit. For a textured top, plan the highlight pattern to follow the direction the hair naturally falls.

3. Perform a patch test 48 hours earlier and put on gloves. Apply barrier cream around the hairline.
4. Section the top of the hair and clip away the sides and back. Work in clean, even sections.
5. Pick up thin pieces with the tail comb. Slide foil under each piece and keep the pattern consistent from section to section.
6. Apply lightener mixed exactly per the manufacturer to the chosen pieces, saturating but not overloading. Fold or seal the foil.
7. Work from the back of the top to the front so the early foils process the longest in the least visible area.
8. Check one foil by gently opening it at the recommended interval. Do not exceed the maximum time on the label.
9. Rinse each foil off at the sink, shampoo with a gentle product, and apply conditioner.
10. Tone if needed, then dry and style to confirm the pieces follow the shape of the haircut.

Common mistakes

- Placing highlights without checking the haircut's direction.
- Overlapping foils so product bleeds into neighboring sections.
- Making pieces too thick, giving a stripe effect.
- Applying lightener to damaged ends.
- Leaving foils on past the allowed time.

Practice drill

On a mannequin, practice picking up pieces and placing foil in a repeatable pattern with plain water in the brush. Aim for even spacing and consistent thickness across at least ten pieces.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep lightener off the scalp as the instructions direct, wear gloves and ventilate. Stop and rinse if the client feels burning or irritation.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Express Highlights on Men https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v5i5imCbHTk	Beth Minardi	Quick highlight application on men's hair
Men's Hair Highlights | Guylights Hair Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e7rg4kzGwxI	The Hair Lounge By Angelina Schofield	Men's highlights (guylights) technique, from sectioning to finish
Full Head Highlights on Short Hair Tutorial | Back to Back Foiling Technique | Kenra Color https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6oeyDHqlrI4	Kenra Professional	Foiling technique for highlights on short hair

5. Toning

> *Neutralize unwanted warm tones after lifting so the finished color looks clean and intentional.*

Estimated practice time: 30-45 minutes

Tools you need

- Toner and compatible developer per manufacturer
- Color wheel or tone chart
- Non-metallic bowl and brush
- Gloves and cape
- Timer
- Color-safe shampoo

Step by step

1. Study the color wheel. Opposite tones neutralize each other: violet cancels yellow, blue cancels orange. Match the correction to the tone you see.
2. Assess the lightened hair in daylight, damp but towel-dried, and identify the exact warmth remaining: yellow, gold or orange.
3. Choose a toner designed to correct that tone, and confirm in the instructions that it is suitable for the lifted level of the hair.
4. Complete a patch test earlier and wear gloves. Protect skin with barrier cream.
5. Prepare the toner exactly as the manufacturer directs and do not combine it with unrelated products.
6. Apply quickly and evenly with a brush, working from the warmest area to the lightest to avoid patchiness.
7. Check frequently during processing. Toner can change tone quickly, so watch the clock and the hair together.
8. Rinse thoroughly with lukewarm water, apply a gentle conditioner and review the tone in daylight.
9. Explain aftercare: toner fades, so the client may need periodic refreshes using products designed for that purpose.
10. Record the product, time and result so you can repeat or adjust the formula next visit.

Common mistakes

- Using the wrong corrective tone, producing a muddy result.
- Toning damp hair that is still wet from bleach rinse without drying properly.
- Over-processing and getting a gray or lavender cast.
- Ignoring uneven porosity.
- Failing to explain that toner fades.

Practice drill

Use test swatches lightened to different warm stages. For each, name the tone, pick the neutralizing color from the wheel, and check your reasoning against the product's guidance.

> **Safety note**
>
> Gloves and ventilation as with any chemical service. Do not use toner on irritated skin or if the patch test showed any reaction.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
STEP BY STEP GUIDE TO APPLYING BLEACH AND TONER https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KJ7tGvHIeTs	MHD	Applying bleach and toner, step by step
TONING BLEACHED HAIR AT HOME | Wella T18 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ElSrgIBBx5U	Victoria Ciftci	Toning bleached hair to remove yellow and brassy tones
WELLA T18 TONER Bleached Hair #bleachinghair #blonde #hairfail #wellat18 #hair #diyhair #bleaching https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ogvfp8LTzX8	DieHardBarbiie	Using a toner on bleached hair and what to expect

6. Safety, patch tests and aftercare

> *Run a safe, documented protocol for every chemical service, and know when to stop or refer.*

Estimated practice time: 30 minutes

Tools you need

- Patch test supplies per manufacturer
- Gloves
- Barrier cream
- Client consent and record card
- Timer
- First-aid supplies
- Color-safe aftercare products

Step by step

1. Explain the service and its risks, including the possibility of allergic reaction, and ask about allergies, medications and scalp conditions.
2. Perform a patch test at least 48 hours before service using the product and method the manufacturer describes. Apply a small amount to the recommended skin area and leave it undisturbed.
3. Check the patch area after 48 hours. Any redness, itching, swelling or blistering means no service. Document the reaction and advise the client to speak with a medical professional.

4. On service day, ventilate the room, wear gloves and keep hands, tools and surfaces clean. Never eat, drink or smoke where chemicals are in use.
5. Protect the client's skin and eyes. Keep a clean towel and water ready for quick rinsing.
6. Never mix unknown products or reuse leftover mixed product. Measure and mix only what the instructions allow.
7. Know the warning signs during service: burning, severe itching, swelling, difficulty breathing. Rinse immediately and call emergency services for serious reactions.
8. After rinsing, give written aftercare: avoid heat styling and harsh shampoos for the period recommended, use color-safe products, and protect the hair from sun and chlorine.
9. Book a follow-up, record everything on the client card and store chemicals as the label directs, out of reach of children.

Common mistakes

- Skipping or rushing the 48-hour patch test.
- Trusting an old patch test from months ago.
- Reusing leftover mixed product.
- Working in a closed room with no airflow.
- Forgetting to document reactions.

Practice drill

Create your own one-page consent and patch-test form and a client aftercare sheet. Walk a practice partner through the full protocol, from questions to documentation.

> **Safety note**
>
> Chemical reactions can be serious. If symptoms are severe, treat it as an emergency and seek medical care. Refer any complex case to a professional colorist.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to do a hair dye patch test? - Dr. Amee Daxini https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sO-HUNlYtXA	Doctors' Circle World's Largest Health Platform	How a hair dye patch test is done and why
How To: Patch Test | Apraise https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z5LBZdBKXa4	Apraise	Performing a skin patch test before coloring
How To: Life After Dyeing & Aftercare | True Sons Grooming https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9d9mYgwivr8	True Sons Grooming	Caring for colored hair after dyeing

Next step

Practice each technique on a mannequin head until you can repeat it with clean results, then move to the next module.